

GIMP for Beginners, Part 2

Understanding Layers

Welcome to the second installation of The GIMP tutorials. In this issue, we will try to understand the most crucial part of image editing—layers. Describing layers in words is pretty arduous.

Initially, working with layers can be a bit intimidating and a newbie will try to avoid it. But once you get used to working with it, layers make editing images child's play. Of course, you need to know a few editing tools and techniques.

What is a layer? In general, it is a combination of materials stacked over each other. But when we talk about image editing, a layer can be best described as a



combination of images forming a single image. The combination of images can either be opaque, transparent or both, depending upon the type of effects you implement.

In layman's terms, consider an opaque background with multiple transparent or opaque sheets, one over the other, combined to form an image.

Figure 1 illustrates how different layer stacks combine together to form an image. I have created only a three-layered image, making it easier for you to understand. The top layer is Johnny Bravo, followed by a wooden border in the second and the background in the last layer. Notice how it looks when they are combined together.

Now, you must be wondering about the need for all the fuss, especially when all of this can be achieved with a single layer itself. Well, yes, you can create similar effects with basic editors like KolourPaint, but when you create an image that way, you don't have control over the different aspects of it. For instance, a similar image created using KolourPaint will not allow you to just move Johnny Bravo's image to any place else. You simply cannot do it! Once you create an image just by pasting on non-layered parts, all the sections pasted will be merged in the background itself, leaving no way to edit it. So if you try to move the 'Bravo' part, the whole image will move along with the background and border. While when working with layers, you have